HIRING WITHOUT WHITEBOARDS

Executive Engineering Directory & Real-World Assessment Playbook

Catalog Scope: 767 Global Companies • 290 Remote-Friendly • 46 India Engineering Centers
Evaluation Criteria: Real-World Take-Home Tasks • Pair Programming • Architecture & System Tradeoffs

1. The Shift to Real-World Evaluation

Traditional whiteboard interviews rely on synthetic CS trivia, synthetic algorithm puzzles (e.g. reversing a binary tree on a blackboard), and high-anxiety brainteasers that fail to predict on-the-job engineering performance. The 767 companies in this directory replace algorithmic trivia with realistic evaluation methods:

• Take-Home Projects: A 2 to 4 hour timeboxed real-world task that mirrors actual production codebases.
• Pair Programming: Working alongside senior engineers on an existing bug, refactor, or feature request.
• System Design & Architecture: Whiteboarding actual high-level systems, data pipelines, and tradeoff evaluations.
• Code Review & Bug Hunting: Inspecting realistic PRs for concurrency issues, edge cases, and code quality.

2. Top Tier Target Employers (Selection Matrix)

Company	Headquarters / Hub	Evaluation Style	Target Roles
Airtable	San Francisco, CA / Remote	5-hr realistic design & take-home discussion	Fullstack / Systems
Basecamp / 37signals	Chicago, IL / Remote	Take-home project & writing samples	Backend / Product
Zapier	100% Remote	Take-home code review & values interview	Automation / Cloud
Adyen	Amsterdam, NL / Global	Take-home assignment & design discussion	Fintech / Payments
Automattic	100% Remote	Paid trial contract project (2-4 weeks)	Distributed Systems
Docker	San Francisco, CA / Remote	Take-home code challenge & pair review	Infra / Containers
GitLab	100% Remote	Open source issue pairing & merge request review	DevOps / Go / Ruby
HashiCorp	San Francisco, CA / Remote	Take-home architecture & system pairing	Cloud Infrastructure
Mapbox	Bangalore, IN / SF / Remote	Conversational review & paid onsite project	Geospatial / Systems
Razorpay	Bangalore, India	On-site pair programming on	Fintech / Microservices

		practical tasks	
GoJek	Bangalore, IN / Jakarta / SG	Pair programming on real domain challenge	High-Throughput APIs
Zerodha	Bengaluru, India	Technical discussion & take-home programming	Trading Platforms / Go
Webflow	San Francisco, CA / Remote	Short challenge + paid freelance contract	Frontend / Canvas UI
DuckDuckGo	100% Remote	Paid project with current team members	Search / Privacy
Medium	San Francisco, CA / Remote	Pairing on real production issues	Publishing Engine
Replit	San Francisco, CA / Remote	Pairing on live container/sandbox environment	Cloud IDE / Compiler
Sourcegraph	Remote	Practical take-home project + architectural walkthrough	Developer Tools / Search
Vercel	Remote / Global	Pair programming on Next.js/React & edge runtimes	Cloud / Frontend Core

3. Candidate Preparation Blueprint

When applying to non-whiteboard companies, candidates are evaluated on operational hygiene rather than algorithmic memorization:

1. Git Hygiene & Commit Granularity: Never submit a take-home project with a single 'initial commit'. Create clean, logical commits with clear messages (e.g. feat:, fix:, test:, docs:).
2. Production Readability & Tests: Include unit tests (Jest, Vitest, pytest) and defensive error boundary handling. Explain design tradeoffs in a clear README.md.
3. Pair Programming Etiquette: Think out loud. Verbalize assumptions, ask clarifying questions on specifications, and treat the interviewer as a collaborative teammate rather than an adversary.
4. System Tradeoff Articulation: Be prepared to discuss CAP theorem compromises, caching hierarchies (Redis/CDN), and asynchronous DAG workflows.